



# **Treatment of Psychological Disorders 1: Navigating the Mental Health System & Approaches to Treatment**

Lecture 19

Summer 2026

Dr. McPhee

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By the end of class today, students should be able to...

- ...Understand how to navigate the mental health system.
  - ...Differentiate between the different professionals that treat mental health concerns and identify places in our community to get help.
  - ...Summarize the reasons why it is important to get **treatment**, and why some people do not seek treatment/ have difficulty accessing treatment.
- ...Describe the differing approaches to treatment.
  - ...Explain the basic principles of **Psychoanalysis**, drawing on its origins in the **Psychodynamic Perspective**.
  - ...Explain how **Humanistic** and **Existential Therapies** differ from Psychodynamic Therapy; describe the basic methods of **person-centered therapy**.
  - ...Explain the similarities and differences between **Cognitive Therapies** and **Behaviour Therapies**, and describe the techniques of **cognitive restructuring** and **Cognitive-Behavioural Therapy**.
  - ...Discuss the **ABC Model** for cognitive restructuring.

# Daily Objectives for Today

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# NAVIGATING THE MENTAL HEALTH SYSTEM

YouTube Link: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hyLEm8D5Hdg&t=640s>



| Job Title                     | Degree                                                                                | What They Do                                                        |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Psychiatrist</b>           | Medical degree (MD)                                                                   | Assess and treat psychological disorders; prescribe medications.    |
| <b>Psychiatric Nurse</b>      | Master's Degree (MSN) or Doctorate and Registered Nurse (RN)                          | Prescribe and manage psychiatric medications.                       |
| <b>Psychologist</b>           | Doctoral Degree (PhD or PsyD). Could be clinical, counselling or school psychologist. | Diagnose and treat behavioural disorders; produce and use research. |
| <b>Clinical Social Worker</b> | Master's Degree in Social Work (MSW)                                                  | Provide mental health care and engage in advocacy.                  |
| <b>Therapist</b>              | Master's Degree (MA or MS)                                                            | Assess and treat psychological disorders.                           |

## Who Provides Treatment?

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- Why should we treat psychological disorders?
  - Personal and social costs.
    - Inability to carry out daily activities.
    - Inability to manage relationships.
  - Financial cost
    - ~\$51 billion per year in lost work.
  - These impairments are just as severe as those associated with physical illness.



## Why get treatment?

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- Getting access to treatment is one of the biggest challenges in mental health.
- 20% of Canadians suffer from a moderate to serious mental health disorder at some point in their lives.
- Only ~40% of these individuals seek treatment.
  - 1/3 of those that seek treatment are unsatisfied with the level of treatment they receive.
- Canada has comparatively great access to mental health treatment.
  - Other countries often present worse figures than these.

# Access to Treatment

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- Why do people fail to get treatment?
  1. People don't realize they have a disorder.
    - People do not typically understand mental illness as well as they understand physical illness.
  2. Psychological beliefs prevent people from seeking treatment.
    - Belief that they can treat themselves (72.6%).
    - Belief that mental health problems are not that severe (16.4%).
    - Belief that they will be stigmatized by others for seeking mental health treatment (9.1%).
      - "I have to leave work early today for a doctor's appointment."
      - "I have to leave work early today for a psychotherapist appointment."

# Access to Treatment

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### 3. There are structural barriers to seeking care.

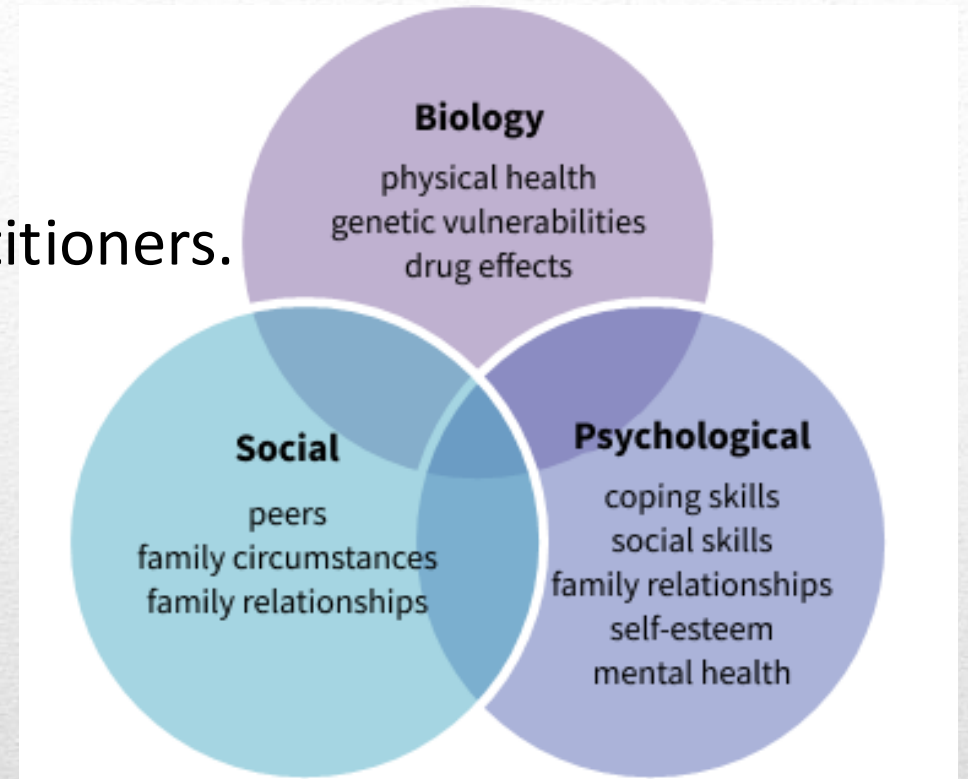
- Knowing where to look.
- Not enough clinicians.
- Cost.
  - How does insurance work with mental health care?
  - OHIP does not cover psychologists/counsellors/social workers.
  - Private insurance often has low limits on these types of professionals.
    - Use your UofT benefits!

## Access to Treatment

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- **Biological Treatments** for the brain.
  - e.g., Psychopharmacotherapy.
  - Used by psychiatrists and psychiatric nurse practitioners.
  - Treat the brain!
- **Psychological Interventions**
  - e.g., Talk therapy.
  - Used by psychologists and other therapists.
  - Treat the mind!
- **Social Environment**
  - Used by social workers.



The Biopsychosocial Model

# Differing Approaches to Treatment

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## Psychological Treatment



Psychotherapy is an example of a psychological treatment.

# Diagnosis



## Biological Treatment



Psychopharmacotherapy is an example of a biological treatment.

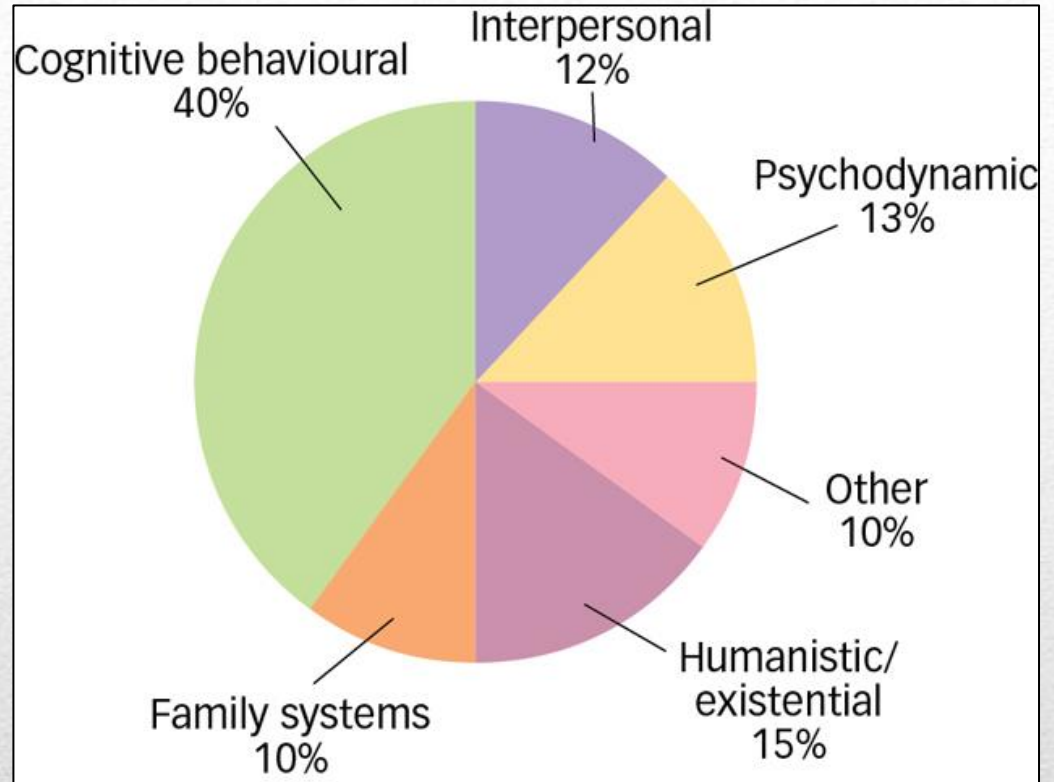
# The Basics of Treatment



- There are many types of psychological treatments, or **psychotherapy**.

- 4 Major Movements of Psychotherapy:

1. **Psychodynamic Therapy**
2. **Humanistic Therapy**
3. **Behaviour Therapy**
4. **Cognitive Therapy**



Types of Psychotherapy Practiced in Canada.

# Psychological Treatments

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- Recall, **Psychodynamic Therapy** has its roots in Freud's methods of **psychoanalysis**.
  - Aims to gain awareness and insight into the unconscious thoughts, feelings and behaviours.
- What sorts of topics do you expect would be discussed in a psychoanalytic session?
  - Childhood Events
  - Dream Analysis
  - Subconscious Thoughts & Urges
  - Projective Techniques



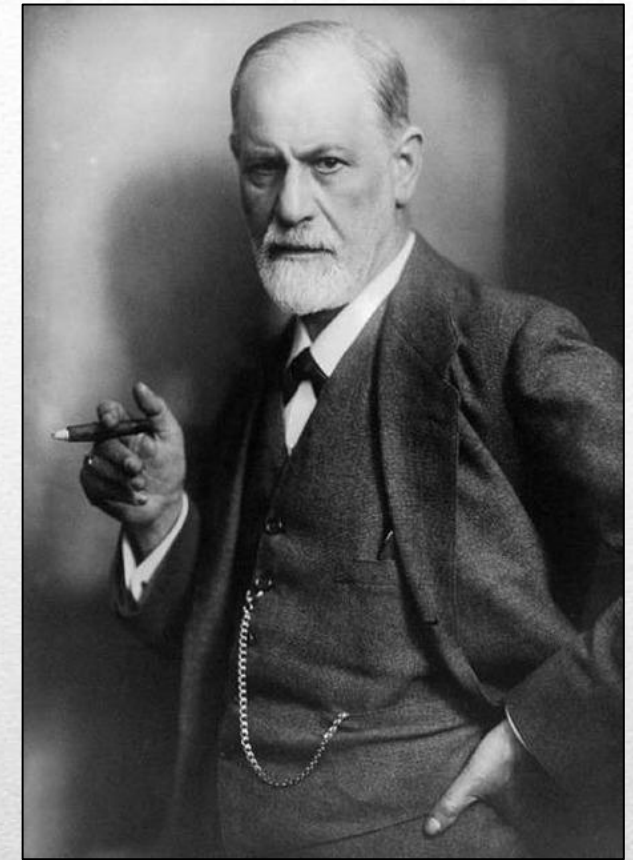
An example of a client participating in a psychoanalytic session.

# **1. Psychodynamic Therapy/ Insight Therapy**

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- This therapy is centred on the belief that psychological problems come from:
  - Ineffectively repressing **urges** (often starting in childhood) → **fixations**.
  - Problematic use of defence mechanisms.
  - Conflict between parts of the **dynamic subconscious**.
    - “What I want to do.” vs. “What I should do.”
- Psychoanalysis attempts to give the patient **insight** into these conflicts. → Insight is the goal!



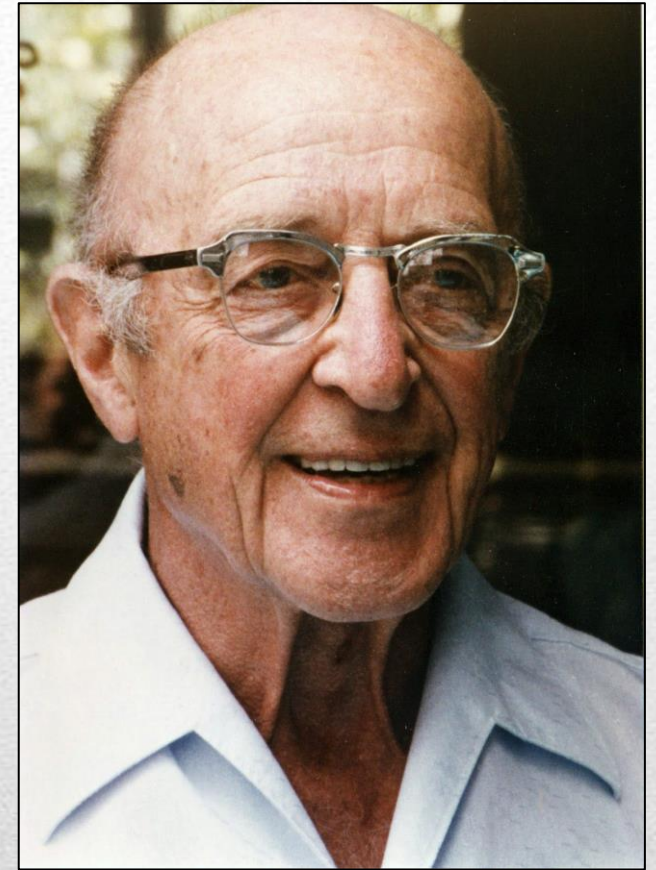
Sigmund Freud. Father of modern psychotherapy.

# 1. Psychodynamic Therapy/ Insight Therapy

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- Review: **Humanistic Theory** and psychologists emphasize:
  - The importance of striving for personal improvement.
  - Free will.
  - The positive aspects of the human experience.
- Goal is to help patients develop a stronger, healthier sense of identity.
- **Person-centred therapy** assumes that individuals have a tendency toward growth; centres on acceptance and genuine reactions from therapist.
  1. **Congruence** (words, body language, etc.)
  2. **Empathy**
  3. **Unconditional Positive Regard**



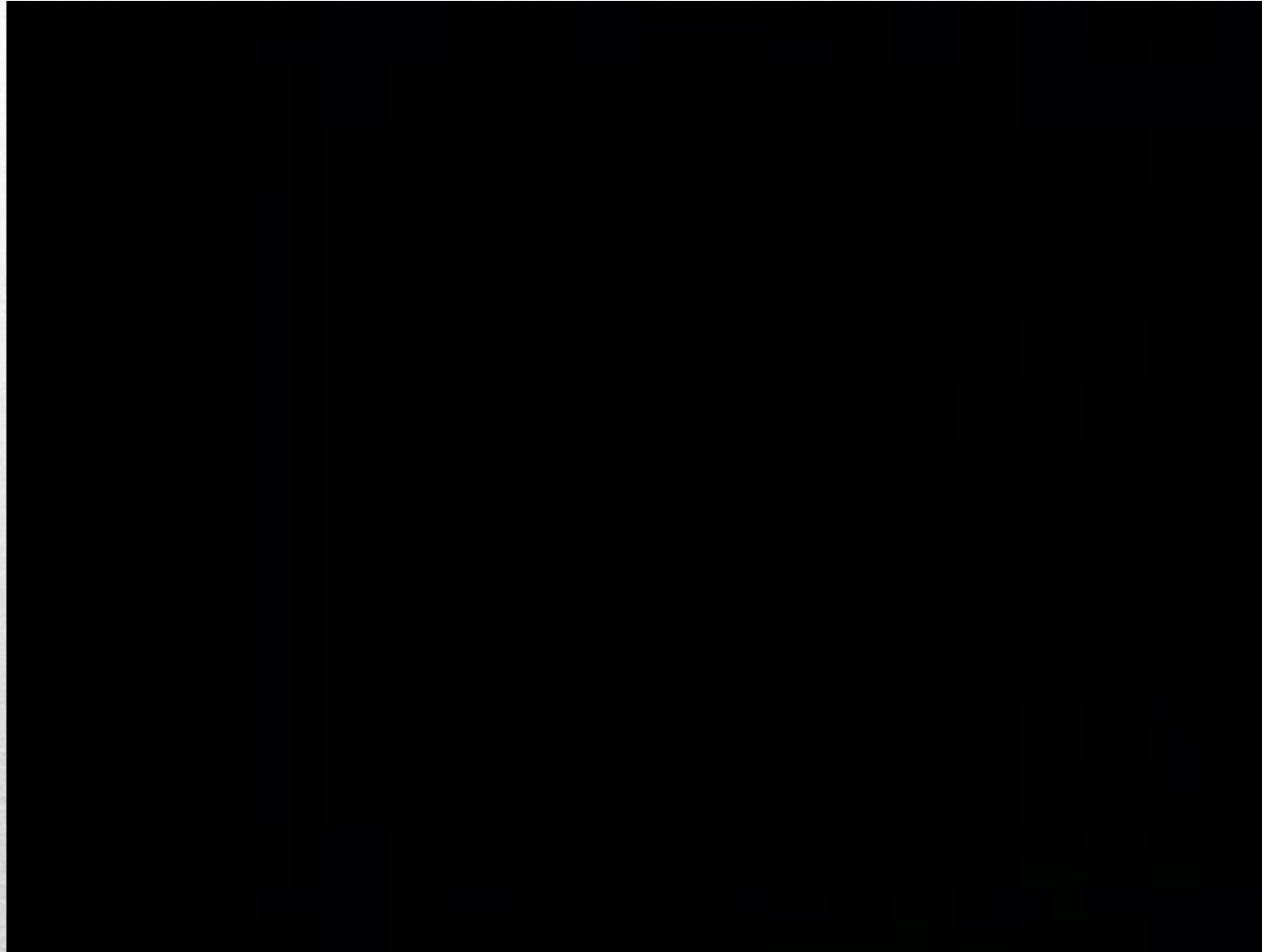
Carl Rogers was a major proponent of Humanistic Theory.

## 2. Humanistic/Existential Therapies

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## Counselling Techniques Used in Person-Centered Therapy



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Link to Video: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ew8CAr1v48M>

- Behavioural and cognitive therapies are the most common type of **psychotherapy** in Canada.
  - Probably because of the wealth of evidence suggesting their efficacy.
- **Behavioural/cognitive therapy** relies on **behaviourism**—study of observable, measurable variables.
  - Focuses on changing behaviour (action) or cognition (thoughts) to combat mental illness.



# Behavioural/Cognitive Therapy

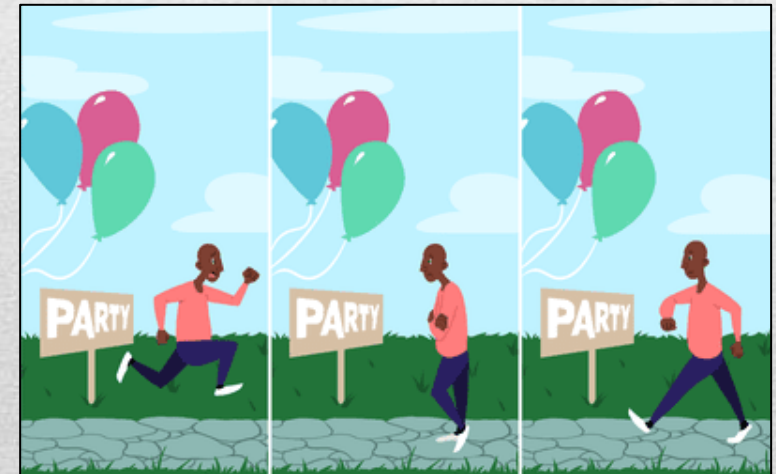
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- **Behavioural therapy** mostly centres around **conditioning**.
- **Operant Conditioning**
  - Rewards for positive behaviour; punishments for negative behaviour.
  - One method is **token economy**.
    - Rewarding positive behaviour with vouchers.
- **Classical Conditioning**
  - **Exposure therapy**.
  - Harmless, repeated exposure to a stimulus believed to be threatening. → Reduction in threat response.



A token economy uses objects to reinforce good behaviour.

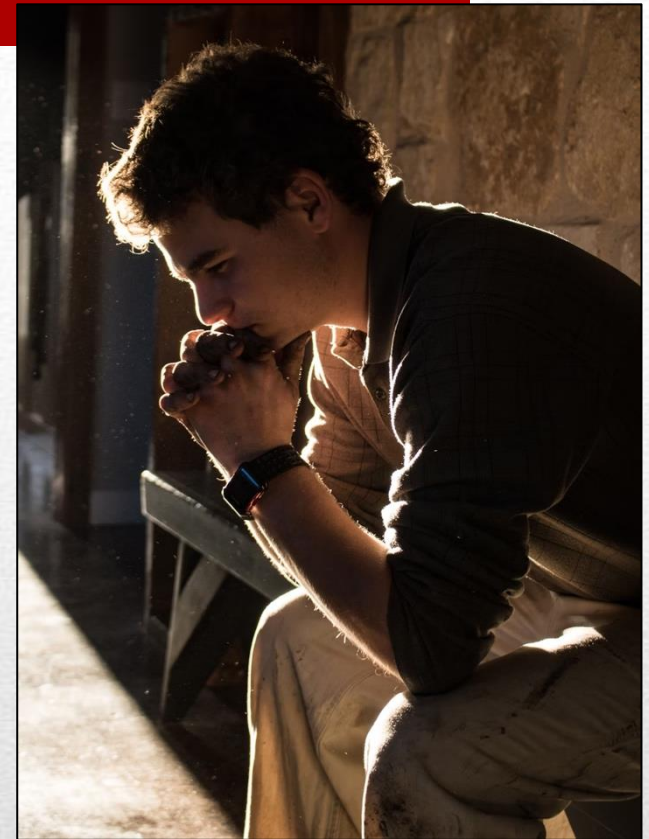


An example of exposure therapy.

## 3. Behavioural Therapy



- Like behavioural therapy works to change actions, **cognitive therapy** works to change unhealthy thought patterns leading to mental illness.
- Cognitive therapists focus on restructuring of irrational, negative thought processes to rational, positive ones.
- A therapeutic approach that teaches clients to question the automatic beliefs, assumptions, and predictions that lead to negative emotions.
  - “I will never be able to make friends.”
    - What friends have you had in the past? Where? When?
  - “I will never be able to succeed in school.”
    - What successes have you had in the past? Where? When?



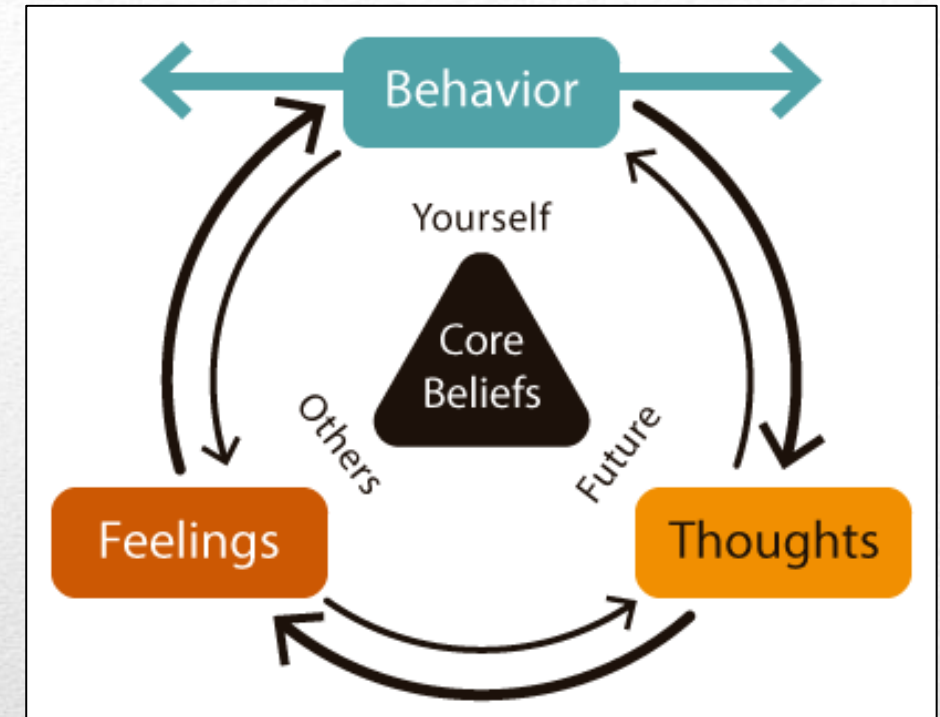
Cognitive Therapy seeks to replace unhealthy thought patterns with rational, positive ones.

## 4. Cognitive Therapy

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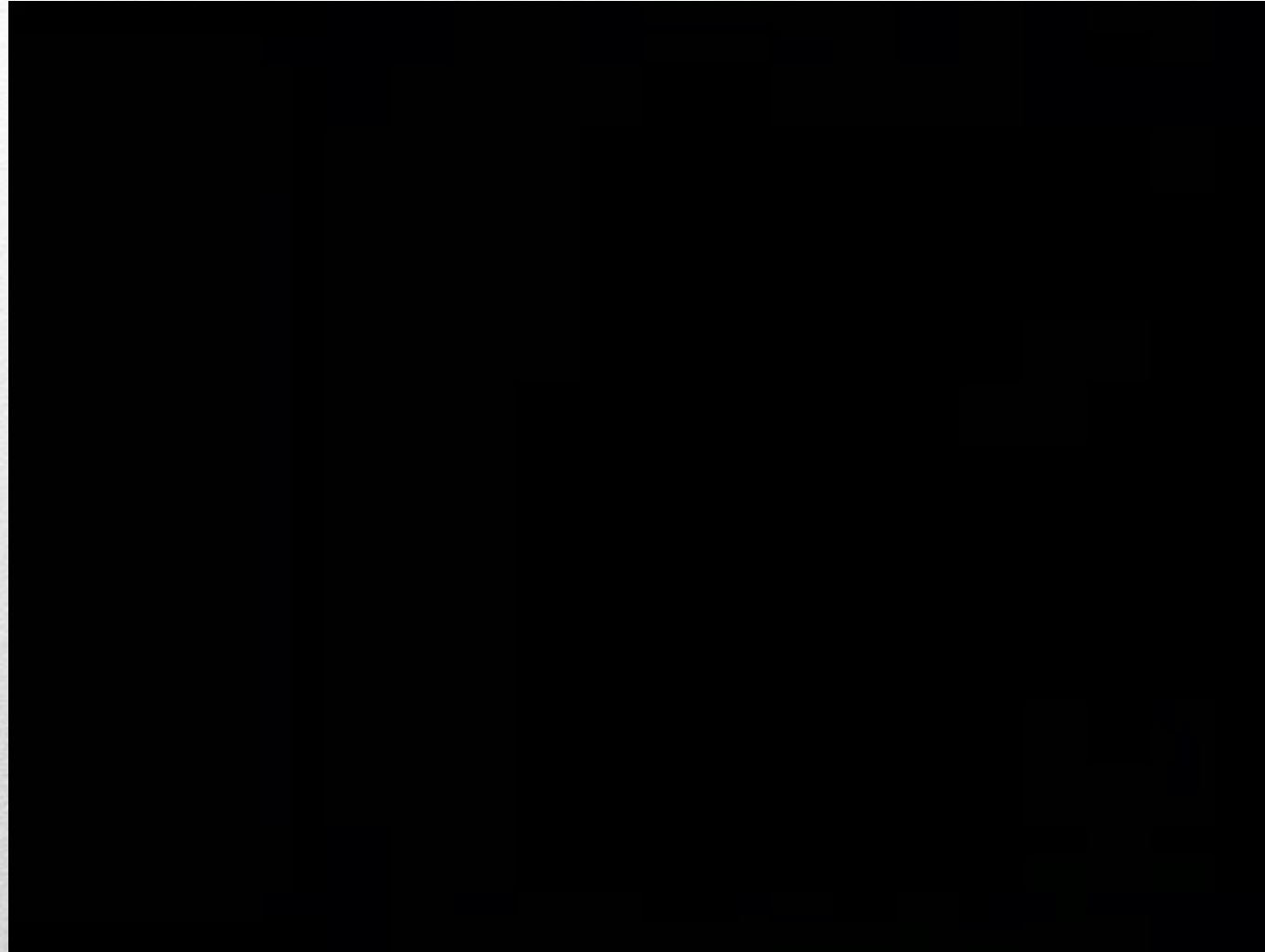
- Many therapists combine **behavioural** and **cognitive** orientations into one technique: **cognitive-behavioural therapy (CBT)**.
  - Most common psychological treatment for depression and anxiety.
  - CBT is:
    - **Problem focused.**
    - **Action oriented.**
    - **Transparent** (unlike psychoanalysis).
  - What is **cognitive restructuring**?



A model depicting Cognitive-Behavioural Therapy.

# Cognitive-Behavioural Therapy

# Cognitive-Behavioural Therapy

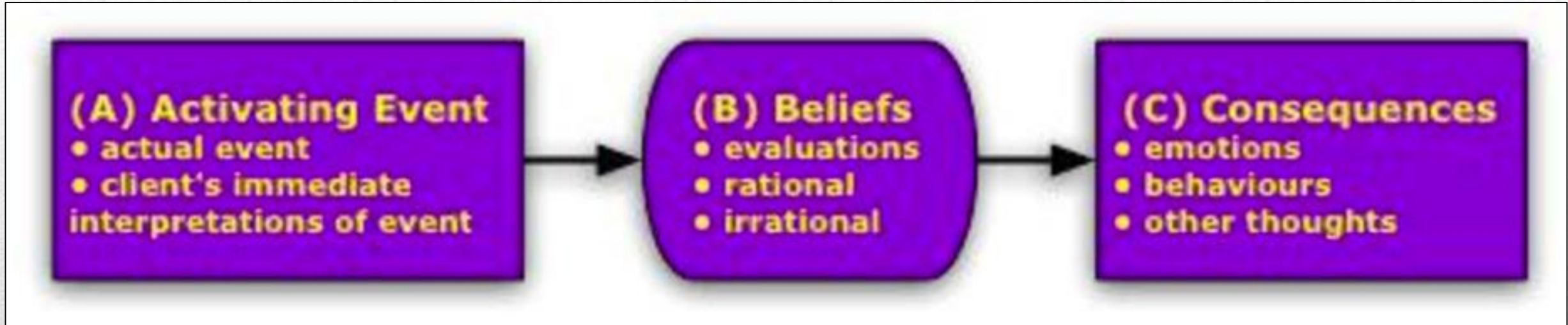


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Link to Video: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GqW8p9WPweQ>



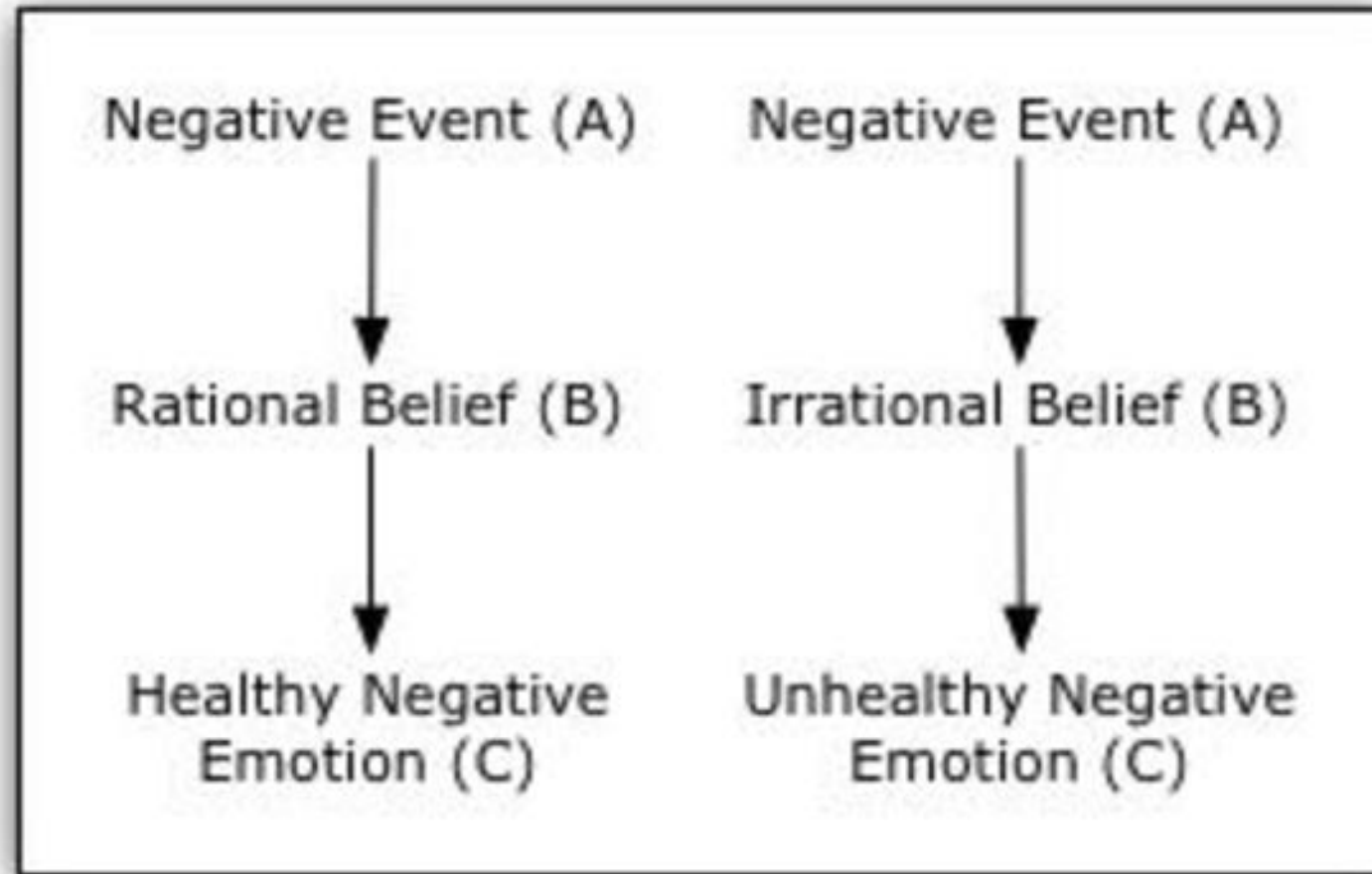
**ABC Model:** Short-term, action-oriented and problem-focused approach.



An illustration of the ABC Model: A refers to the activating event, B refers to the beliefs, and C refers to the consequences.

# ABC Model

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Two possible pathways in the ABC model. One pathway leads to the experience of healthy, negative emotions, whereas the other path leads to unhealthy, negative emotions.

## **ABC Model: Two Paths**



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